

**TABLE III**  
**INTERNET/BROADBAND SUBSCRIBERS**

| Internet/broadband subscribers | In million | Subscriber density (Subscribers/100 population) |
|--------------------------------|------------|-------------------------------------------------|
| Total                          | 342.65     | 26.98                                           |
| Urban                          | 230.71     | 58.28                                           |
| Rural                          | 111.94     | 12.80                                           |

Source: The Indian Telecom Services Performance Indicators January 2016 - March 2016, TRAI

**TABLE IV**  
**TYPE OF INTERNET SUBSCRIBERS (IN MILLION)**

|                      |        |        |
|----------------------|--------|--------|
| Wired/wireless       | 20.44  | 322.21 |
| Narrowband/broadband | 192.90 | 149.75 |

Source: The Indian Telecom Services Performance Indicators January 2016 - March 2016, TRAI

are poor compared to urban (152 per cent).

**Infrastructure.** Village public telephones (VPTs), a primary means of voice communication, have been provided in 98.12 per cent villages as of December 2015. VPTs are expected to be provided in remaining villages through Universal Service Obligation Fund (USOF), a financial corpus lying with the government and generated by annual contribution of a percentage of revenue earned by telecom companies.

To increase rural tele-density through wireless means, a plan to build 7353 mobile towers to provide services to uncovered villages (cluster of villages) having a population of 2000 or more was initiated. As of December 2012, 7310 towers (99.42 per cent) were set up and 16,023 base transceiver stations were commissioned, according to DoT's annual report of 2012-2013.

Despite efforts to provide infrastructure, most rural areas have only 2G coverage. Mobile subscriptions that come bundled with Internet connectivity do not have speeds comparable to broadband. Key constraints cited in providing 3G are aggregation and backhaul. This is echoed in Mbit Index by Nokia Solutions and Networks, which shows that although 3G in India grew by 146 per cent year-

**TABLE V**  
**MARKET SHARE**

| Market share (per cent) | Public sector | Private sector |
|-------------------------|---------------|----------------|
| Total                   | 10.22         | 89.78          |
| Wireless                | 8.70          | 91.30          |
| Wireline                | 72.42         | 27.58          |

Source: The Indian Telecom Services Performance Indicators January 2016 - March 2016, TRAI

on-year basis in 2014, the growth is limited to cities.

**Internet usage.** A snapshot of Internet subscriber connectivity is given in Tables III and IV. Once again, rural subscriber density (subscribers/100 population) is half the total and one-fourth the urban density.

Almost 40 per cent of rural Internet users used community service centres and cyber cafes to access the Internet in 2013. The figure was 71 per cent in 2009; the fall is perhaps due to the growth in mobile tele-density. A large number, almost 54 per cent, reported having to travel a distance of more than 10km to access the Internet.

As regards the purpose of accessing the Internet, email was the preferred application (85 per cent), followed by music and video (67 per cent), education information search (48 per cent), general information search (42 per cent) and text chat (40 per cent). Data also shows that around 84 per cent

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